

POU11011 — Marking rubric

Blog post (30%) and final essay (60%) · Michaelmas Term 2026

Dr Noah Buckley

This is how the blog post and the final essay are marked. Read it **before** you write. It applies to both pieces; where the two differ, the difference is noted.

The five criteria

1. **Argument** — a claim a reasonable person could disagree with, defended.
2. **Use of concepts** — are the module's concepts doing work, or being described?
3. **Evidence** — real, specific details from real cases, supporting the argument rather than decorating it.
4. **Structure and writing** — can the reader follow it, and is it in the right register? (*For the blog post that means blog, not essay: hook, short paragraphs, headings and links that earn their place.*)
5. **Referencing** — accurate, consistent, and only sources you have actually read.

Criteria 1–3 carry most of the mark. Criterion 5 carries the least, but sloppy referencing is visible and it costs. The gap between a II.2 and a II.1 is almost always the gap between *describing* a concept and *using* it; the gap between a II.1 and a first is almost always answering the strongest objection to your own case.

The bands

Marks follow Trinity's scale, as set out in the School's marking descriptors.

Band	Argument and use of concepts	Evidence	Structure, writing, referencing
I — 70+ <i>First</i>	A clear, independent argument that answers the question directly. Concepts are integrated with evidence rather than reported; there is real critical evaluation, and at least one original connection between ideas the lectures did not make for you. Handles the strongest objection to its own case.	Well-chosen, precise, drawn from more than the set readings. Cases are compared, not listed.	Lucid. Every paragraph earns its place. Referencing accurate and consistent throughout. <i>Above 79: independence of judgement, imagination and originality throughout.</i>

Band	Argument and use of concepts	Evidence	Structure, writing, referencing
II.1 — 60–69 <i>Upper second</i>	Sound and well-organised, with a clear position and no significant errors. Deals completely with the question. Evaluation is present but largely derivative — it follows the readings' own arguments rather than pressing beyond them. Not necessarily excellent in any one area.	Accurate and relevant, mostly from the module readings, and genuinely supports the claims.	Coherent and cogent; the reader is never lost. Referencing sound, minor slips only.
II.2 — 50–59 <i>Lower second</i>	Substantially correct and shows understanding of the basic principles, but the argument is not really developed. Concepts are defined accurately and then applied thinly, or applied to a case that is too large to say anything specific about. Draws largely on the textbook and lecture notes.	Present but general. Cases are described more than analysed.	Clear enough, but organisation is loose or the register is wrong for the genre. Referencing inconsistent or incomplete.
III — 40–49 <i>Third</i>	Basic understanding of the main issues, but the piece is descriptive only and does not answer the question directly. Assertions are not supported by argument or evidence. Key points missing; some serious inaccuracies.	Sparse, vague, or not connected to the claims.	Hard to follow; no clear line. Referencing minimal or erratic.
F — below 40 <i>Fail</i>	Misunderstands basic material, or fails to answer the question set. Information inadequate; presentation incoherent. (<i>Below 30: virtually no appropriate material.</i>)	Absent or wrong.	Incoherent. Absent or unusable referencing.

Two rules markers apply consistently across all TAs:

- A good piece of writing that **strays from the question set** is normally capped in the II.2 band, however well written it is.
- A piece that would otherwise be a II.1 but is **too short, rushed, unfinished or badly organised** is normally marked at the top of the II.2 band.

Penalties, applied after the band mark: three per cent for exceeding the word limit; five marks per day, to a maximum of twenty, for late submission. Both are set out in the [module outline](#).

Discussion points — pass/fail

Discussion points are **not** marked against the bands above. They are pass/fail, and the bar is genuine engagement, not quality.

Pass	Three numbered points, at most a page, submitted on time. Each point engages with the actual reading or lecture material and raises something arguable — a question, a challenge, a connection, a case that fits badly. Rough prose is fine.
Fail	Substantially short of the required length; a summary of the reading with no point of your own; generic remarks that could have been written without opening the text; or submitted after the deadline.

Two points per tutorial attended **with** an accepted submission, to a maximum of six across three tutorials. Attendance without a submission, or a submission without attendance, earns nothing for that tutorial. Full detail: [discussion points handout](#).